

The Agency Fund 

APPLICATIONS SESSION · AGENCY IN INSTITUTIONAL AND HUMAN CAPITAL DEVELOPMENT CONFERENCE

Applications of “agency”

Lessons from The Agency Fund and its AI for Global Development Accelerator

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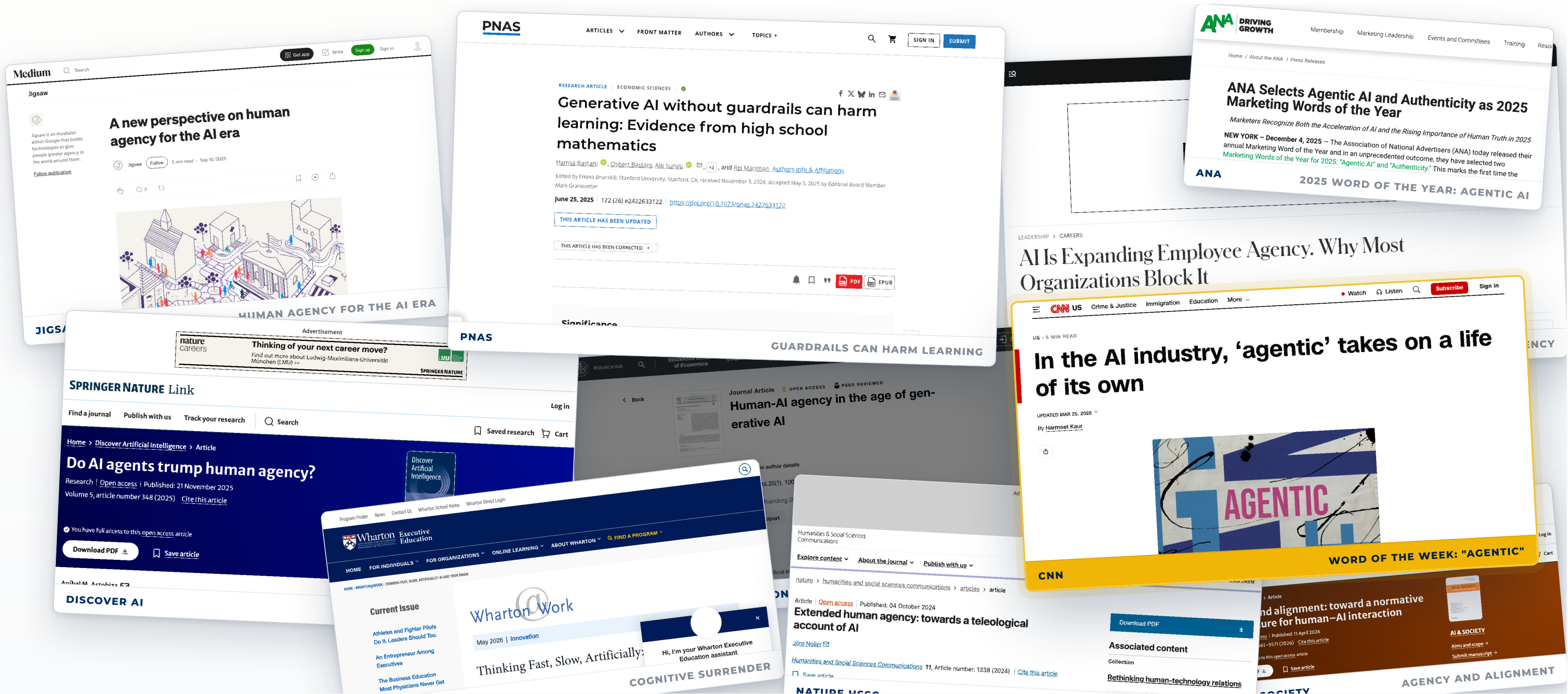
Princeton University · September 26, 2026

If you speak a second language, think about the word “agency” in your own language.

Is there a good translation?

AI can expand agency, and it can hamper it.

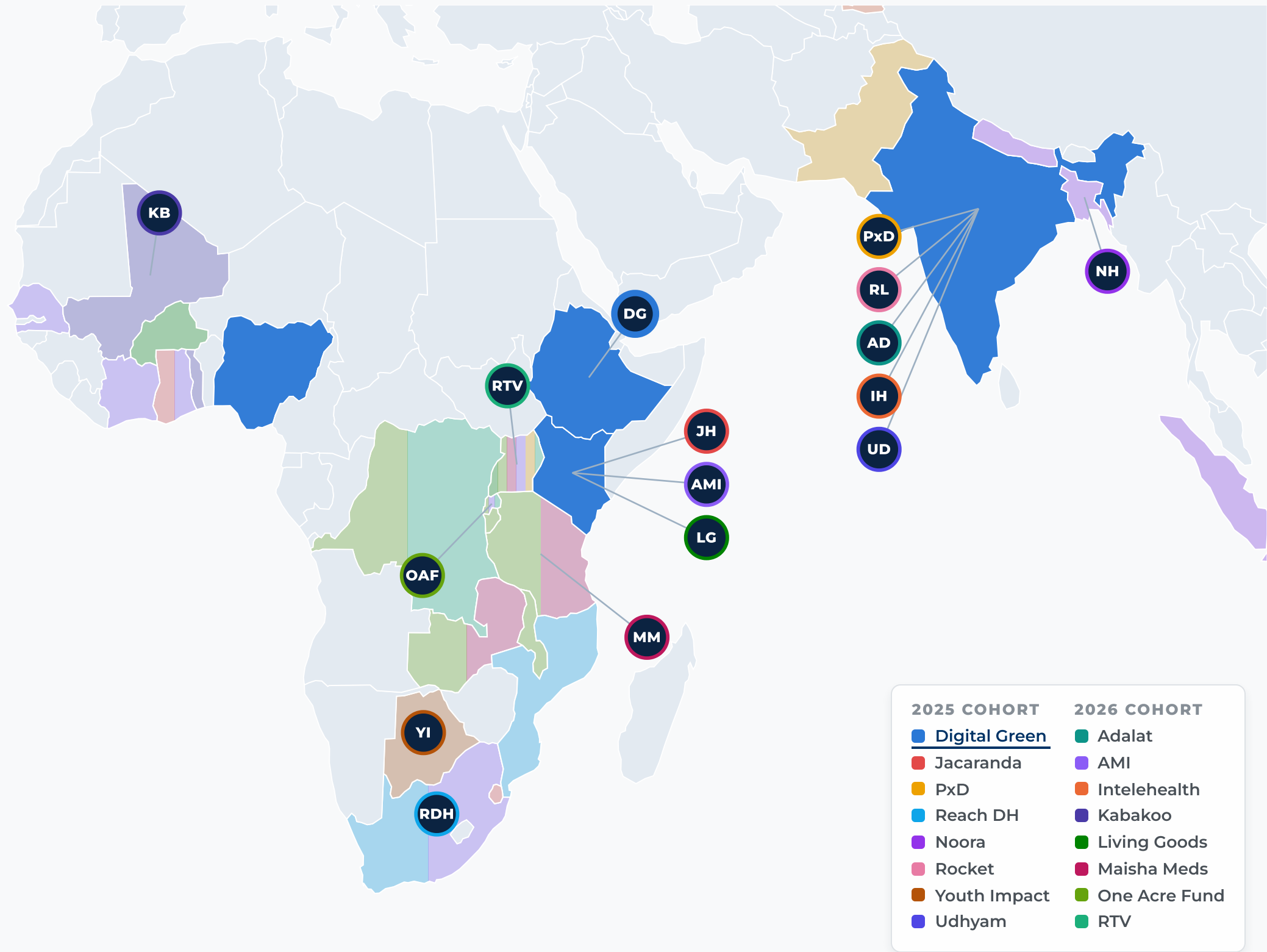
Agency is the AI-era buzzword: "agentic" was CNN's Word of the Week in March 2026, and the Association of National Advertisers picked "agentic AI" as a 2025 Marketing Word of the Year.



Sources: [CNN Word of the Week](#); [ANA 2025 Word of the Year](#); [Jigsaw](#); [Bastani et al., PNAS](#); [Shaw & Nave, SSRN](#); [Forbes employee agency](#); [Forbes real-world agency](#); [Forbes human agency](#); [Discover AI](#); [AI & Society](#); [Nature HSSC](#); [Human-AI agency](#).

We worked with NGOs globally to design and evaluate their AI products through accelerator programs.

INTERACTIVE Click the map, chips, or legend to focus an org · click empty space to clear, or Reset



Digital Green
2025 COHORT

FarmerChat

A multilingual AI agronomy advisor for smallholder farmers, using text, voice, and images to deliver localized recommendations.

- L1 · MODEL** Model stack is live across 16 languages, with text, voice, image evals and over 100% improvement over the base model.
- L2 · PRODUCT** 1M+ users have generated 8M+ queries; 30% are monthly active and average 8.7 queries per month.
- L3 · USER** About 70% of active users report applying FarmerChat advice; 80% share advice with peers.
- L4 · IMPACT** Kenya assessment finds adoption of cost-saving practices; income and climate-resilience outcomes are in ongoing RCTs.

AI PRODUCT IN: INDIA · KENYA · NIGERIA · ETHIOPIA · BRAZIL
ORGANIZATION OPERATES IN: INDIA · KENYA · NIGERIA · ETHIOPIA · BRAZIL

Working with these organizations surfaced **two gaps related to human agency** for AI products in the social sector.

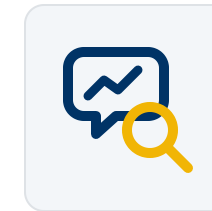


THE DESIGN GAP

AI products are built to optimize service delivery, rather than explicitly to strengthen people's agency.

Despite AI's potential to strengthen human agency, NGO products often treat agency as a byproduct rather than an explicit design objective.

Decades of research in [psychological science](#) and [psychologically wise interventions](#) identify agency as a key mechanism for improving development outcomes, yet it is rarely **intentionally built into AI design, testing, or iteration.**



THE MEASUREMENT GAP

AI products are underused as windows into how human agency evolves.

Many products may not generate as many signals of agency as tools like ChatGPT or Claude Code do. Even when these signals exist, they often come from power users, and the field lacks a shared standard or analytical tools for **measuring and interpreting agency** inside human-AI digital traces. Recent advances in LLM as a measurement tool (e.g., [OpenAI's Gabriel](#) and [Google's Langextract](#) offer promising solutions beyond traditional NLP methods.)

The Agency Fund 

PART 2 · REPEATABLE MOTIONS

**We create repeatable motions
based on our work with the
NGOs.**

Open-source tools, papers, and AI skills that connects psychological science with AI

A research library of agency interventions

A Google NotebookLM as an interactive agency intervention learning assistant

notebooklm.google.com · Agency-Based Intervention Assistant

Agency Intervention Learning Assistant by The Agency Fund

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Ecological Systems Theory

Implementation Science

Intervention Mapping

Planned Behavior Theory

Psychological Interventions

Self-Determination Theory

Social Cognitive Theory

Social Policy Research

Chat

Agency Intervention Learning Assistant by The Agency Fund

29 sources · Jan 3, 2026

Icek Ajzen's 1991 paper introduces the **Theory of Planned Behavior**, a psychological framework designed to predict and explain human actions. This model expands upon the earlier **Theory of Reasoned Action** by adding the concept of **perceived behavioral control**, which accounts for activities that individuals cannot fully influence through will alone. The author argues that **intentions**—driven by personal attitudes, social norms, and the perceived ease of an action—serve as the primary motivators for behavior. While empirical evidence largely supports the theory, the source also explores **unresolved issues** such as the role of past habits and the impact of moral obligations. Ultimately, the text demonstrates that combining **motivation and perceived ability** provides a highly accurate method for understanding how complex social behaviors are formed.

Save to note

what is agency

Agency is the capacity to intentionally make things happen by one's actions; it involves the endowments, belief systems, and self-regulatory capabilities through which people exercise influence over the nature and quality of their lives. It is the essence of humanness.

Gemini Notebook just got smarter. Try asking to create documents and spreadsheets.

Ask a question or create something

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Flashcards

Quiz

Infographic

Data Table

New Note

Architectures of Human Agency and Intervention...

How to Use This Notebook

[Quiz] Q&A on the Core Theoretical Ideas

[Flashcards] Core Theoretical Ideas

[Table] Summary of Theories and Applications

[Audio] Behavioral Science Theories f...

[Flashcards] Pra...

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Gemini Notebook can be inaccurate; please double check its responses.

A research library of agency measurement tools

A Google NotebookLM for finding, comparing, and adapting agency measurement tools, co-developed with Google Jigsaw

notebooklm.google.com · Agency Measurement Tool Library

Measuring Agency in a Digital Context @ The Agency Fund & Jigsaw

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Identity

Methods

Motivation

Other

Political Science

Self-Efficacy

Social Behavior

Technology

Theories of Agency

GenAI Evaluation Playbook in the Development Se...

Chat

Measuring Agency in a Digital Context @ The Agency Fund & Jigsaw

184 sources · Jun 21, 2026

Customize

Welcome to this NotebookLM collection on **measuring agency in digital contexts**.

This notebook brings together theoretical papers, useful scales, and other resources on how agency can be understood, measured, and supported in digital environments. It was created as companion material for a blog drafted by [The Agency Fund](#) and [Jigsaw](#).

You can use this notebook to explore the research, compare measurement approaches, and brainstorm ideas for measuring agency in digital contexts. Please note that tags shown in the left sidebar are generated by NotebookLM.

Like any AI tool, NotebookLM can be helpful for thinking with documents, but it can also make mistakes. Please use it at your own discretion and refer back to the original sources when accuracy matters.

We hope this notebook serves as a useful starting point for research, discussion, and new ideas around measuring agency. We also welcome your feedback through [this form](#).

Creator Notes

Save to note

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Data Table

Taxonomy of Agency and Agency-Related...

184 sources · 48d ago

Agency Map

184 sources · 48d ago

Agency Flashcards

184 sources · 48d ago

How AI erodes your agency

21:21 · Deep Dive · 182 sources · 56d ago

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A review paper that connects AI eval with cultural defaults

An interdisciplinary paper from the accelerator's AI eval working group, PNAS Nexus (under review)

PNAS Nexus, 2026, , 1–13
DOI added during production
Published: Date added during production
Paper



Evaluating AI Across Cultures: A Multilevel Framework for Generative AI in Global Development

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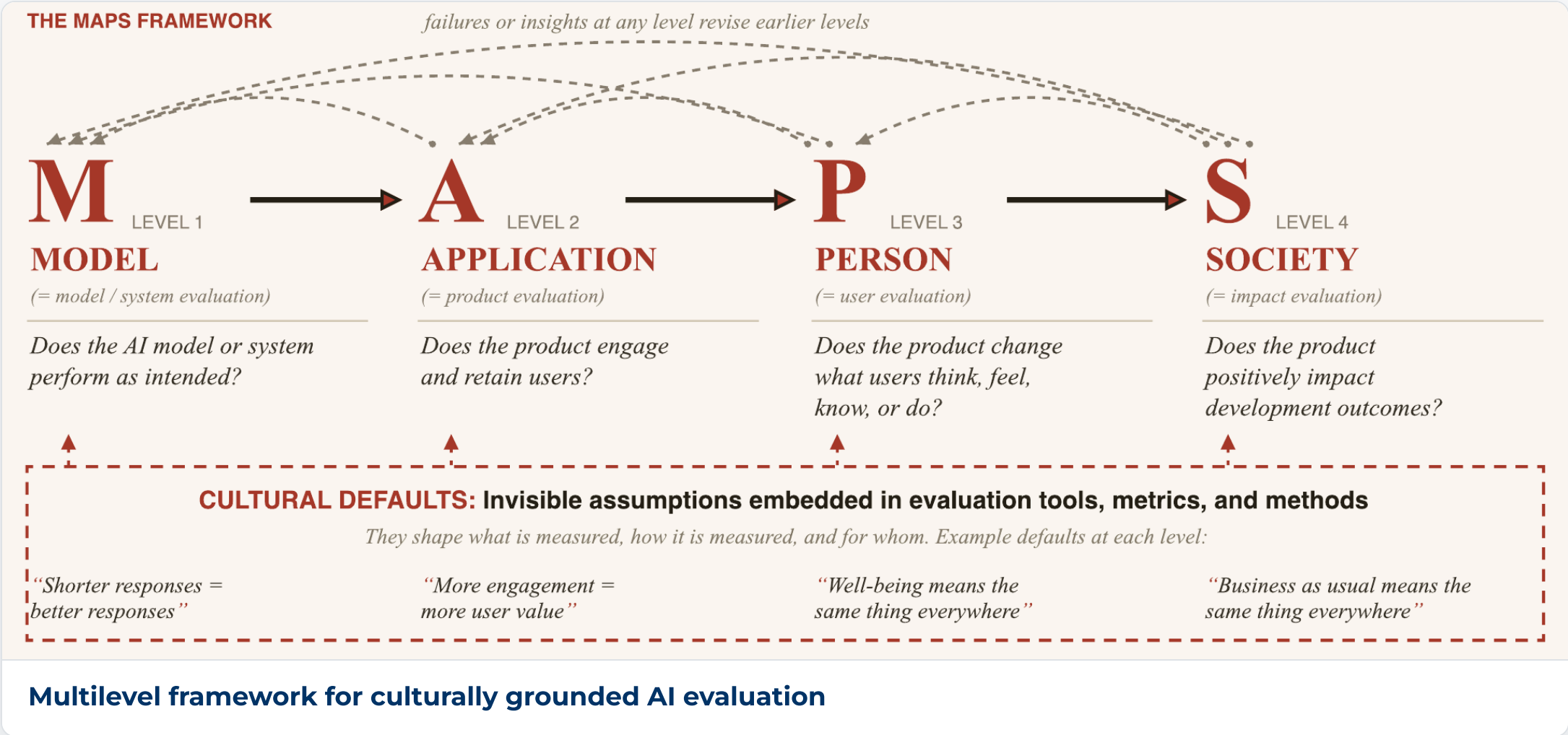
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Abstract

Generative AI tools are being deployed at scale across low- and middle-income countries as health chatbots, agricultural advisors, educational tutors, and beyond, yet the frameworks used to evaluate them were developed within Western, English-dominant, commercially oriented contexts. This cultural mismatch creates a structural problem: evaluation tools that function well in high-income settings can produce systematically flawed conclusions when applied to diverse global populations. Drawing on insights from a multidisciplinary working group spanning computer science, economics, behavioral science, public health, and linguistics, we introduce a four-level evaluation framework MAPS (the Model, its Application, the Person who uses it, and the Society it affects), designed to make explicit how culture shapes AI evaluation at every level. We argue that culture operates not as a moderating variable to be statistically controlled but as a set of defaults: invisible assumptions embedded in benchmarks, engagement metrics, psychological measures, and outcome assessments. When these defaults do not match the deployment context, evaluation produces artifacts rather than evidence. Grounding the framework in case studies from AI deployments across Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia, we show how culturally responsive evaluation differs from standard practice at each level and propose a research agenda for this emerging field.

Keywords artificial intelligence, culture, evaluation, global development, language diversity, WEIRD

Paper draft



Behavioral science skills that amplify existing AI workflows

Claude skills on behavioral science by The Agency Fund and Irrational Labs (e.g., [behavioural-skills](#); [taf-skills](#))

● ● ● joe-speed.github.io/behavioural-skills

🔗 Behavioural Skills

Catalogue Workflow Builder Propose a Skill

🔍 Search 🔍

🌟 Star on GitHub 0

A curated, chainable library of atomic AI skills for behavioural science — each one narrow enough to describe without the word "and," built so one skill's output can feed the next.

Search skills by name or description...

CATEGORY

All

Behaviour Definition

Diagnosis

Intervention Design

Measurement

Research Methods

Segmentation & Personas

Risk & Pre-Mortem

Cultural Context

Evidence Scoping

Researcher Calibration

Context Mapping

Research Transparency

RESEARCH STAGE

All

Prepare

Define

Diagnose

Design

Test

Measure

Report

COM-B Barrier Decomposer

Diagnosis Diagnose

Use when one specific, already-defined target behaviour exists (a clear who + what + when, not a goal or outcome) and the question on the table is "why isn't this happening yet?"

Context & Audience Mapper

Context Mapping Prepare

Use when a program goal names its target population only in the abstract identity terms a funder or stakeholder would use (e.g. "smallholder farmers", "gig workers", "first-time mothers") with no detail on the actual...

Install

Select skills from the list to build a combined install command.

INSTALL COMMAND

Copy, paste, run. Updates as you change platform or selection.

Platform

macOS / Linux

Selected: 0

BASH

Copy

curl -sSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/Joe-Speed/behavioural-skills/main/scripts/install.sh | bash -s -- --target . --name <select-skills>

Advanced

Behavioral-science skills for applied AI workflows

● ● ● Claude Skills · Agency Measurement

The Agency Fund

Afternoon, Zezhen

/ask-agency-measurement

what is agency and why should I measure it?

+ Sonnet 4.6 High

🎤

🔄

Agency-measurement skills for research and evaluation

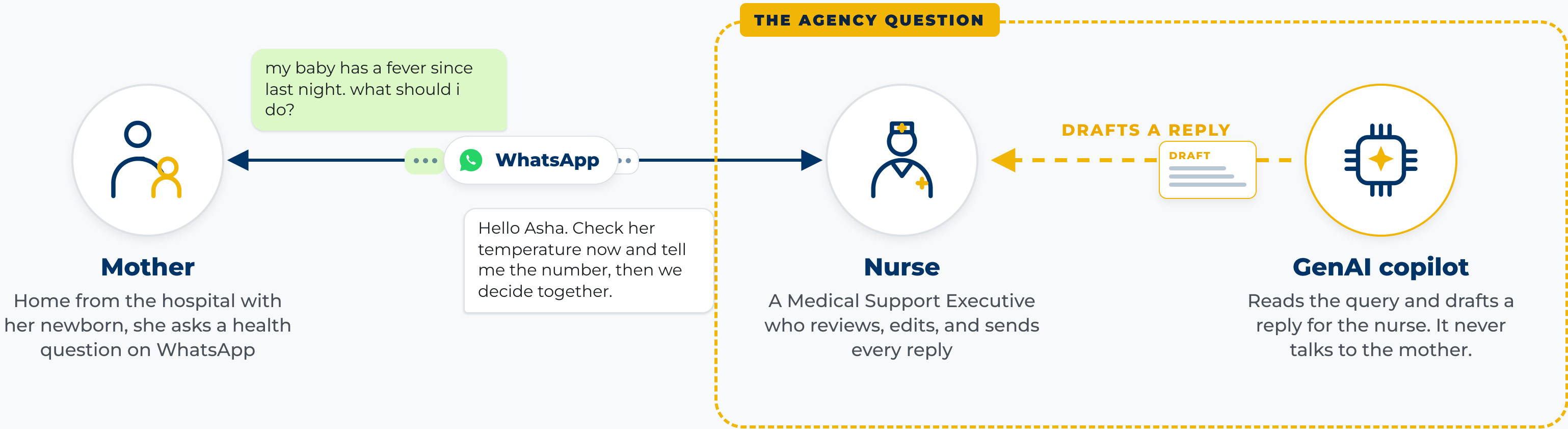
PART 3 · RESEARCH: DESIGNING AI FOR AGENCY

**We bring psychological science
into the design of AI products in
the social sector.**

We are working with several NGOs in the accelerator to test out preliminary ideas, but there are a lot of rooms for innovation in this design space.

Evaluating a medical professional copilot to align AI design with the agency of the humans in the loop

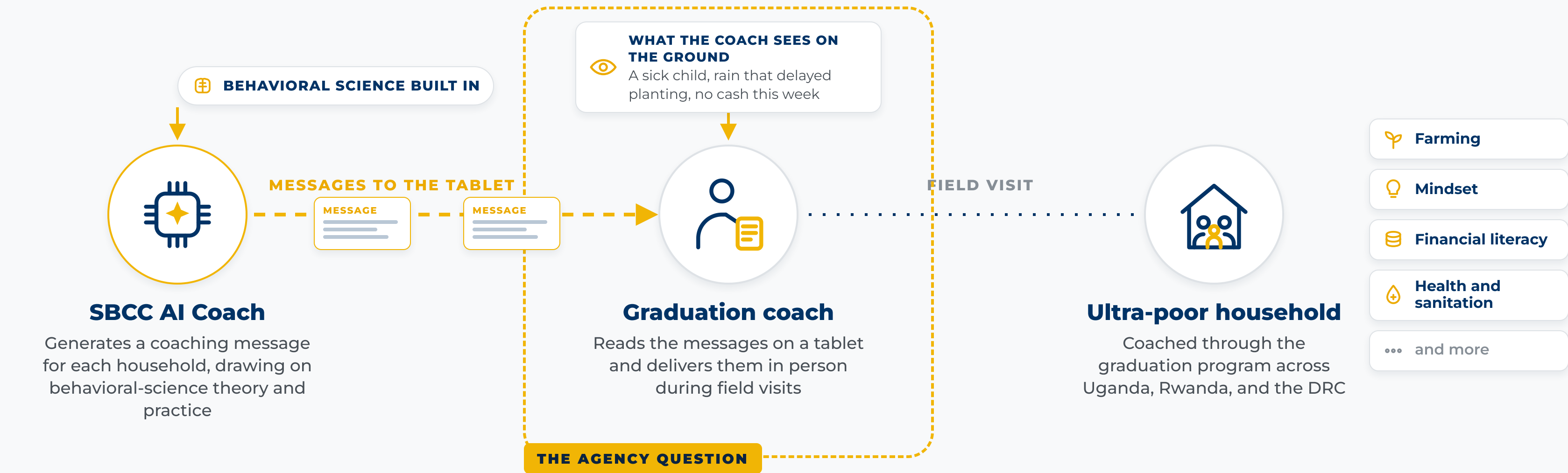
A mixed-methods case study with Noora Health and the Stanford Center for Health Education



The agency question sits with the nurse: how does she use the copilot to support the mother? The copilot's effects run through her judgment, so the study asks whether the tool **expands her capacity to care or quietly narrows it.**

Designing AI-personalized coaching to support field-agent agency in household behavior change

A design and evaluation study with Raising The Village's SBCC AI Coach



The agency question sits with the coach: how do we align AI-generated messages with what the coach can flexibly deliver, given the situations they meet on the ground? The messages have to **support the coach's judgment, not script it.**

There is a whole new field of literature on bringing psychology inside AI design and evaluation.

DESIGN

THE CORE ARGUMENT

Chatbots could democratize personalized support, or deepen isolation and risk. The difference is whether **psychological theory and methods are embedded** in design, evaluation, and monitoring, with concrete roles for psychologists across that whole pipeline.

FLIP BACK

ALIGNMENT

THE CORE ARGUMENT

AI should be understood as an **extension of human purposiveness**, grounded in practical autonomy: the human capacity to act for reasons and take responsibility. Alignment then runs through a normative interface connecting machine behavior to human norms, with humans remaining the ultimate bearers of responsibility.

FLIP BACK

EVALUATION

THE CORE ARGUMENT

Benchmarks reward accuracy, reasoning, and compliance, but say little about whether a system supports **user cognition, emotional interpretation, and behavioral decision-making** in ways fit for the user and context. The authors propose testing this with scenario-based probes and structured human and model-assisted evaluation.

FLIP BACK

FIELD

THE CORE ARGUMENT

AI systems increasingly mediate social, cultural, economic, and political interaction. Understanding their effects requires an interdisciplinary **science of machine behavior** that combines computer science with behavioral, social, and cognitive science methods.

FLIP BACK

We also see a unique opportunity in bringing the **science of wise psychological interventions** into AI design.

We are working on practical guidelines and papers for agency-supportive AI using wise intervention techniques.

- Education assistants that protect belonging by helping users interpret struggle as a normal part of learning, rather than evidence that "people like me don't belong here."
- Health or livelihoods coaches that strengthen users' sense of control by helping them recognize meaningful choices and act on options available to them.
- AI messaging tools that deliberately test how small changes in language shape identity, social norms, and motivation - for example, framing an action as part of "who I am," not just something to do.

We create tools for **measuring agency in human-AI interactions.**

Agency can be experienced internally or expressed externally through choices and actions. There is also a wide array of on-platform and off-platform data that we can use to concretely understand and measure context-specific agencies.

We created a guideline for **measuring agency in a digital context**

[A practitioner's guide](#) co-cocreated with Google Jigsaw



Summary

- The Agency Fund and Google Jigsaw have co-developed a free set of resources and AI tools to help measure how digital and AI tools shape human agency in practice: an open-source [Claude Skill](#) that helps you brainstorm alongside this blog and a curated [NotebookLM](#) with useful papers and measurement approaches.
- **Why should tech teams care about agency?** Research increasingly shows that digital and AI tools can expand human agency; but when poorly designed or implemented, they can also undermine it.
- **What is agency in the context of digital and AI tools?** Agency is a person's capability to navigate toward the future they want. It can be experienced internally (e.g., feeling capable or empowered) or expressed externally through choices and actions. Agency may concern a user's end goals independent of technology, or their ability to shape, control, and effectively use a tool in pursuit of those goals.
- **How do we measure agency?** It should be measured as an outcome, not inferred from engagement alone. Teams should specify what agency means for their specific users and contexts. We suggest three broad steps:
 - Define agency for your local problem
 - Choose the right measurement tools for the right type of on-platform or off-platform data, measured at the right moment
 - Test and validate the measurement tools iteratively

What you need to measure also depends on the forms of agency and how agency manifests in your product.

Hypothetical example: an AI mentor helping learners develop a viable business idea

Agency with respect to the end goals

Can users make progress toward outcomes they value, whether through, around, or beyond the tool?

Internally experienced agency

People's thoughts and feelings

ON-PLATFORM DATA • IN-APP MICRO-SURVEY
Short in-app surveys providing users' general sense of self-efficacy or perceived control over their ultimate goal over time (e.g., "How confident is the user about developing a successful business idea? How much control do they feel over reaching their ultimate goal?")



OFF-PLATFORM DATA • PHONE OR IN-PERSON SURVEY
Longer phone/in-person surveys using validated agency measures that systematically probe users' general sense of self-efficacy or perceived control over their ultimate goal over time.



FLIP BACK

Externally expressed agency

People's choices and actions

ON-PLATFORM DATA • CONVERSATION LOGS
Longitudinal user signals of agency in AI conversation logs, especially those related to setting and navigating longer-term goals or demonstrating resilience despite difficulties.



OFF-PLATFORM DATA • RUBRIC-RATED PITCHES
Longer phone/in-person surveys tracking how users develop their business ideas; rubric-rated observations of ideas and pitches; or classroom observation of teamwork, ideally linked to downstream outcomes like business earnings.



FLIP BACK

Agency with respect to the AI tool

Can users understand, question, adapt, and control the tool, deciding when and how to rely on it?

ON-PLATFORM DATA • IN-APP MICRO-SURVEY
Short in-app surveys providing whether users felt able to understand, question, or adapt an AI mentor's advice.



OFF-PLATFORM DATA • VALIDATED SCALES
Longer phone/in-person surveys using validated agency measures that systematically probe users' trust in IA and perceived dependence versus empowerment when using a tool.



FLIP BACK

ON-PLATFORM DATA • DIGITAL TRACES
Digital traces (e.g., interaction patterns or conversation logs) showing whether users understood, question, or adapt an AI mentor's advice.



OFF-PLATFORM DATA • OBSERVATION AND INTERVIEWS
Observation or interview data (e.g., usability studies) on tool usage for developing business ideas.

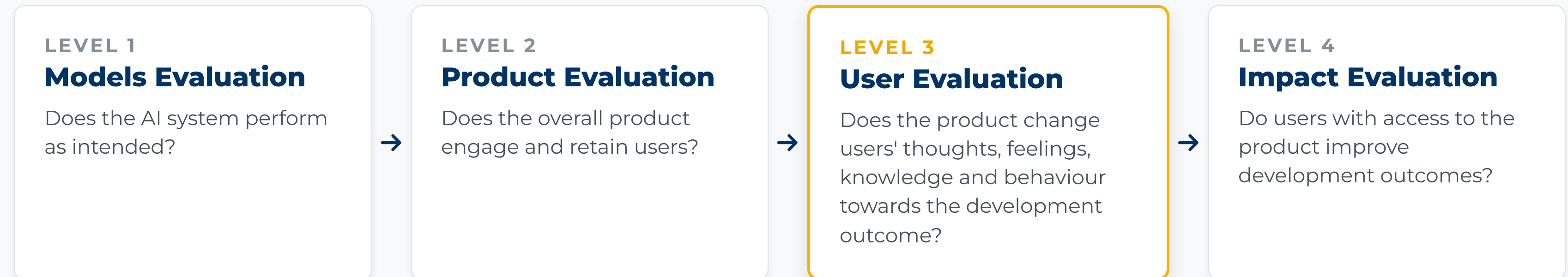


FLIP BACK

 **Mind the social setting:** norms and relationships can also shape these questions; interpret the answers in your users' contexts.

Agency measurement sits at **Level 3**

The four-level evaluation framework · eval.playbook.org.ai



Nobody can run an RCT on every product change. **Validated agency measures at Level 3** move when the product changes, and they speak to what Level 4 cares about. That also allows teams to anchor their A/B tests on intermediate measures that are psychologically and behaviorally meaningful and relatively easy to collect.

Teams should specify what agency means for **their specific users and contexts**

1

Define agency for your local problem

What kind of agency is the tool supposed to support? **For whom? To what end?** Anchor the definition in your program's theory of change.



2

Measure with the right tools, on the right data, at the right moment

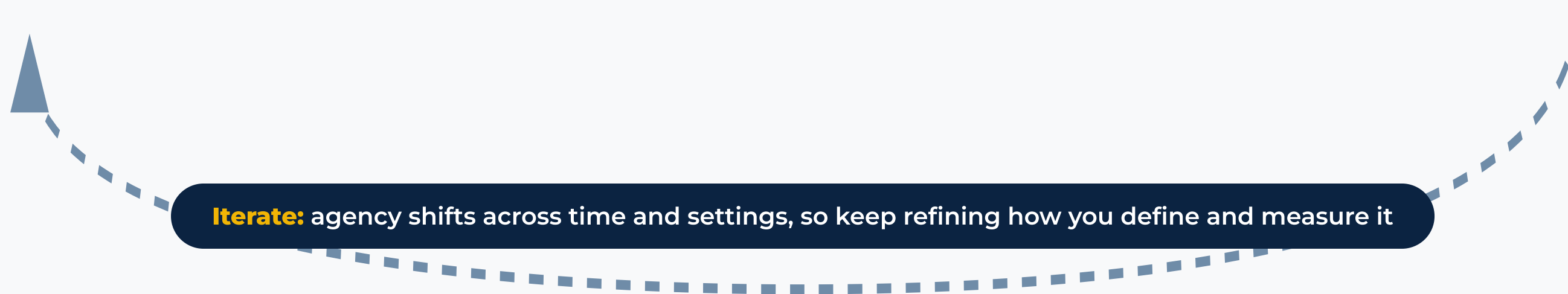
Combine **on-platform** signals, such as in-app surveys and digital traces, with **off-platform** surveys, interviews, observations, and records.



3

Test and validate your measurement tools iteratively

Test for evidence of **reliability and validity** for your context.



Workshops help NGOs identify signals of agency in human-AI conversations.

INFORMATION DELIVERY

< A A²C Health Line

AI assistant · online

Today

hello. my feet r swelling in the evening. i am 7 months pregnant

10:14 ✓

Hello Priya. Mild evening swelling is common in month 7. It helps to:
1. Rest with your feet raised.
2. Drink water through the day.
3. Avoid standing for long.
Go to the clinic if swelling is sudden or comes with headache or blurred vision.

10:15

ok. can i still do house work

10:22 ✓

Light housework is fine. Avoid heavy lifting and take short breaks.

10:23

ok thank you

10:26 ✓

Message

GOAL SETTING AND NAVIGATION

< A A²C Health Line

AI assistant · online

Today

hello. my feet r swelling in the evening. i am 7 months pregnant

10:14 ✓

Hello Priya. Evening swelling is common in month 7, and resting with feet raised helps. Have you managed your ANC check-up this month?

10:15

not yet. clinic is far and my husband takes the scooter for work

10:21 ✓

That is a real constraint. The 7th-month check matters — they will look at this swelling and your BP. Which day is he home?

10:22

thursday, home by 2

10:24 ✓

Then a plan: Thursday at 3 he drops you at the clinic. Carry your mother-child card. Shall I remind you at 1?

10:25

yes pls. thursday 3 pm i will go

10:27 ✓

Message

The flagship study: Measuring agency in a digital context

Proposal · with Hamsa Bastani and Osbert Bastani, University of Pennsylvania · six NGO partners

MAIN IDEAS FROM THE PROPOSAL

Use LLMs to measure whether digital platforms strengthen people's agency.

- 1 Start from real traces:** text, voice, video, decisions, and linked outcomes from digital and AI products.
- 2 Judge agency beyond product engagement:** e.g., score intentionality, forethought, self-reactiveness, and self-reflectiveness.
- 3 Track change over time:** estimate agency at key moments and mark uncertainty when evidence is thin.
- 4 Validate lightly:** combine expert labels with targeted surveys where they add the most information.

The practical output is a **shared measurement tool** that helps product teams improve outcomes through the lens of agency.



Jacaranda Health
HEALTH · KENYA

Agency signal: how mothers ask, decide, and follow care pathways in PROMPTS conversations, linked where possible to care-seeking and visits.

DG

Digital Green
LIVELIHOODS · KENYA, ETHIOPIA, INDIA

Agency signal: whether FarmerChat users move from advice-seeking to applying or sharing agronomy guidance across product versions.



Kabakoo Academies
LIVELIHOODS · MALI

Agency signal: learner voice/video reflections that reveal goals, confidence, follow-through, and later livelihood progress.

N

Nova Escola
EDUCATION · BRAZIL

Agency signal: how teachers use a WhatsApp lesson-planning copilot to co-create, adapt, and reuse classroom plans.

APPRENTICE

The Apprentice Project
EDUCATION · INDIA

Agency signal: students' creativity, persistence, and next choices after TAP Buddy feedback, including mother-tongue voice interactions.



Udhyam Learning Foundation
EDUCATION · INDIA

Agency signal: chat and submission traces that show grit, motivation, self-efficacy, and entrepreneurial follow-through.

**Let's build AI that
strengthens human agency,
and **prove that it does.****